performance under him—no doubt reflected in the affluence and splendour noted by foreign travellers like Barbosa and Paes in his capital city. Stein calls it ‘a parasitic regime that extracted tribute from the productivity and commerce of its peoples and contributed little itself to either’. This sounds a little harsh but is mostly on the mark. Other scholars of Vijayanagar, like John Fritz and George Michell, see the capital city not ‘as a natural trading center but rather as an artificially created emporium sustained by courtly patronage, to which much of the wealth of the empire was diverted’.[19]

One could also see Vijayanagar as having become ‘what Nilakanta Sastri called a “war state”, one ruled by warrior-chiefs whose whole being was bent on attaining ever greater military force to be applied to any enemy, Hindu and Muslim’.[20] Brute force was applied to subordinate states too. In 1544, the king of Vijayanagar, Rama Raya, sent a large force to punish the raja of Travancore, Unni Varma, who had apparently not been sending enough trade tributes. Over time, Vijayanagar had moved towards a feudal patrimonial state, especially in the sixteenth century. Scholars, however, still debate the precise nature of political and economic subordination within this imperial pyramid, especially its regional variations.[21]

The imperial governors were often outsiders to their regions—say, Telugus or Kannadigas stationed in Tamil country. They couldn’t rule by force alone, at least not for long. Sustainable rule required cultivating goodwill and appeasing local power brokers. Some did this by investing in irrigation works like dams and tanks and providing competent civic administration. The locals likely also benefitted by gaining greater access to a larger market for their goods like cotton, rice, indigo, oil seeds and textiles, still transported via bullock carts and boats but now over longer distances.[22]

More shrewdly, these outsider governors patronized existing temples and funded new ones, turning their vicinities into urban centres of commerce, artisanal trades and culture. The temples, in turn, often funded irrigation works and other public goods. The imperial governors also donated land and money to priests and to mathas, the powerful monastic orders attached to big temples. Lo and behold, the governors and their descendants began gaining the religiously sanctioned right to rule, which had earlier vested in